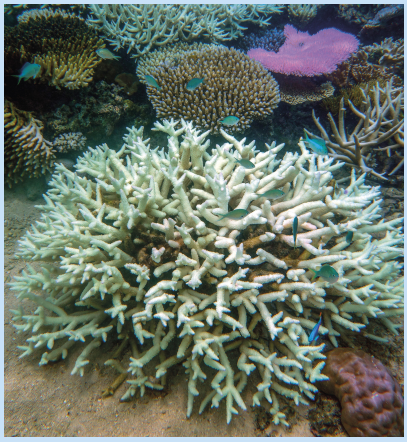
Threatened coral reef biomes



Coral reefs are such bountiful habitats that they are often seen as the tropical rain forests of the sea. They support a quarter of all marine species and provide livelihoods for half a billion people. Yet they are facing catastrophe. Half of the global coverage of living coral has been lost since the 1950s and some experts estimate that 90 percent will be gone over the next 30 years. The main threats are ocean acidification and global warming. As seas warm, stressed corals expel the algae they rely on for food. They stop growing, lose their colour, and often die in what is called a coral bleaching event. Such events are becoming ever more frequent. There are local threats, too, including overfishing, both for the table and for aquariums. Even more seriously, to catch fish for aquariums, sodium cyanide is often squirted into the water to temporarily immobilize the fish, and this kills corals. More brutally, fish for the table are often caught by throwing dynamite into the water. This kills fish, making them easy to scoop up in vast numbers, but it also blasts coral reefs apart.

The climate factor

The one common factor in all biome classifications has been climate, although other “abiotic” factors can also play a part. Climate determines the form of plant growth best suited to a region, and plants that grow in a certain way are restricted to particular climates. The leaves of deciduous trees are broad, with a large surface for light absorption, but little resistance to drying out or frost. Conifer tree needles, on the other hand, are narrow